

Krzysztof Żarna

University of Rzeszów

<https://orcid.org/0000-0002-6965-8682>

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# The internet

## Summary

**DEFINITION OF THE TERM:** The article discusses theoretical issues related to the role played by the internet in the contemporary world. It outlines the historical process of the development of the internet and the positive and negative consequences of its functioning.

**HISTORICAL ANALYSIS OF THE TERM:** This section presents the historical genesis of the development of the internet and the successive milestones that have influenced its shape in recent decades.

**DISCUSSION OF THE TERM:** The internet as a social phenomenon and its role in the globalisation process is of interest primarily to sociologists, media experts, and social psychologists. The internet offers not only the possibility to communicate and obtain information but also freedom of expression, which is often otherwise abused or restricted. The internet is also a culture-creating factor.

**SYSTEMATIC REFLECTION WITH CONCLUSIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS:** This section analyses the technological, social, political, and cultural dimensions of the internet and emphasises the point that the internet accelerates the process of globalisation.

**Keywords:** the internet, globalisation, the history of the internet, communication, social media



## Definition of the term

Numerous definitions of the term 'internet' can be found in the literature; however, it is difficult to provide one single and adequate definition (the term 'internet' is an abbreviation of international network) of this term because it is used in various contexts and is a dynamically developing concept.

In its universally accepted definition, the internet is described as a worldwide computer network which connects local networks using the packet-switched communication protocol TCP/IP and has uniform rules for addressing and naming nodes (computers connected to the network) and protocols for sharing information.

In the computer science definition, the internet is a space of IP addresses allocated to hosts and servers connected by network devices, such as network cards, hubs, and modems, which communicate via the Internet Protocol (IP) using communications infrastructure.

According to Anthony Giddens, a British sociologist and lecturer at Cambridge University, the internet is a global system of connections between computers, which allows people to communicate with one another and find information on the World Wide Web using visuals, sounds, and text in a way that escapes time and space and the cost limitations of distance – and also the control of territorial governments (Giddens, 2006, p. 1021).

According to Bryan Pfaffenberger, the internet is a rapidly growing worldwide system of interconnected computer networks. It offers many services, such as remote user login, file transfer, e-mail, and news-groups. Each computer connected to the internet has its own uniquely assigned number, which is an address (Pfaffenberger, 1999, p. 111).

The uniqueness of the internet as the dominant medium of today consists in its bringing together the functions of all media: it can influence users through images, sound, words or animation, as well as through other perception techniques. According to Jan van Dijk, "the Internet has even become the most multifunctional medium in history. Increasingly, both old and new media integrate the following functions: information, communication, transaction, entertainment, sociability, education and identity" (Dijk, 2005, p. 205).

Manuel Castells proposes the notion of a 'network society', for which information and communication technologies are the constituting

element of a new type of society in the 21<sup>st</sup> century (Castells, 2011). Castells' proposal fits in with a number of other popular concepts that describe contemporary society: Alvin Toffler uses the term 'third-wave' society, Ulrich Beck 'risk society', Peter F. Drucker 'post-capitalist society', Daniel Bell 'post-industrial society', and Marshall McLuhan 'global village' society (Demczuk, 2020, p. 45).

## Historical analysis of the term

The origins of the internet date back to the USA in the late 1950s and early 1960s. During the Cold War period, the prospect of a nuclear conflict motivated those responsible for state security to start analysing the problem of how the authorities and the army command would function in such circumstances. They realised that in the course of a nuclear clash there was a possibility that most means of communication would cease to exist, the consequence of which would be the paralysis of the state's military forces. The result was the establishment by the US Defence Department of the Advanced Research Projects Agency (ARPA), which comprised scientists whose task was to research key issues for the development of security, establish an internet network, and carry out advanced scientific projects to serve military purposes. ARPA was established in 1958 by President Dwight Eisenhower. At that time, the US Defence Department began a research project to construct a military communication network with a decentralised structure in which the destruction of one section would not interrupt the operation of the entire system (Castells, 2011, pp. 5–6).

The creator of the intercomputer concept was a computer scientist and psychologist called Joseph Carl Robnett Licklider. In 1962, he predicted the emergence of graphic user interfaces, digital libraries, and e-commerce. In his work *Man-Computer Symbiosis*, he predicted the emergence of interactive computer systems as he believed that close cooperation between man and computer would allow the capabilities of machines and the human mind to be more fully exploited. His idea was implemented a few years later with the birth of the internet (generally considered to be on 29 October 1969) when the first data transmission was carried out. At the time, four computers at American universities in

California and Utah were connected, and the letter 'L' was successfully transmitted. The American mathematician, Paul Baran (who was born in Grodno), took part in the research (Goban-Klas, 2005, p. 149). Baran was the inventor of packet switching, a method of data transmission that involves dividing a data stream into chunks (packets) and then sending them via communication links between network nodes. Each packet is subject to separate routing; it can follow a path to its destination independent of the paths of previously transmitted packets.

Throughout the first decade, the Advanced Research Projects Agency Network (ARPANET) continued to grow, although this was a slow process of development. Educational institutions were allowed to join ARPANET provided they received government funding. The agency still operates today under a different name (the Defence Advanced Research Project Agency (DARPA)) and reports to the US Defence Department. In 1970, the first version of the File Transfer Protocol (FTP) was launched, thanks to which software libraries and drivers for hardware and documentation appeared on the internet. A year later, the first e-mail was sent to the person sitting next to the sender, Raymond Tomlinson, an American engineer and programmer. At the time, he was testing the ARPANET network and had prepared a special program for sending messages which he installed on two computers. It is not known what the content of the message was, but it was probably a random string of characters that not even the author of the e-mail himself remembers. The @ sign was then used for the first time to distinguish between local correspondence and that which was sent via the new network (Leszczyńska, 2019, p. 15).

In 1972, TELNET was created. This was an application that allowed computers to connect and run programs remotely. In the same year, the College of London and the Royal Radar Establishment (a research centre in Malvern, Worcestershire, UK) were incorporated into ARPANET. In 1974, the word 'internet' first appeared in a research paper written by Robert E. Kahn and Vinton G. Cerf's *A Protocol for Packet Network Intercommunication*, which was devoted to the Transmission Control Protocol (TCP). A year later, the first e-mail discussion box was created by Steve Walker. In 1976, Mike Lesk from American Telephone & Telegraph developed the Unix Copy Protocol (UCP), which was used during the development phase of newsgroups (now called discussion groups), i.e., Usenet. In 1977, one hundred scientists were connected

by e-mail via TheoryNet, and a mailing list was then established. IP and TCP protocols were also developed. In 1978, the first Bulletin Board System (BBS) was launched in Chicago, which gradually offered software libraries, e-mail, chat, discussions, and games. A year later, chatting over the internet became available for the first time. Usenet newsgroups were created by Steve Bellovina, Jim Ellis, and Tom Truscott, who were students at the time (Leszczyńska, 2019, p. 16).

In 1983, the military part was detached from ARPANET to form MILNET, which is how the internet proper came into being. A year later, the government agency the National Science Foundation joined in the development of the internet and created NSFNET, a network of supercomputers used for scientific purposes. The online service Prodigy was then created, which had a shopping function and allowed access to information. In 1988, the first instant messaging service resembling today's IRC (Internet Relay Chat) was created. In the same year, the first computer virus attacked the web (Leszczyńska, 2019, p. 16).

In 1991, the programmer Timothy Berners-Lee and scientists at the European Particle Physics Laboratory created the World Wide Web protocol, a networked information exchange system that offered its users direct access to databases without the use of search engines. This project, in its first iteration, allowed hypertext documents to be edited and viewed simultaneously and was based on Hyper Text Markup Language (HTML). The emergence of the web browser brought the internet to the entire world. This web-based system made it possible to combine text, images, and sound and was originally intended to support physicists at the European Laboratory for Particle Physics. T. Berners-Lee's work was a continuation of studies into the possibility of interactively accessing connected information sources via computer networks, for which a database accessible through network mechanisms was invented. The WWW was also a set of information that could be browsed through a network, but it had no web pages. Unlike today's web pages, which are full of graphics, moving elements and videos, the original WWW pages were based solely on text and functioned by means of users clicking hypertext links that led to other places. T. Berners-Lee also introduced another tool called hypertext (today known as hyperlink or link). This system was installed on the servers of the European Laboratory for Particle Physics and spread worldwide (Castells, 2011, pp. 53–54).

In 1993, Mosaic, the first graphical web browser, appeared. This was the prototype for today's Internet Explorer, Netscape, and other browsers. At the time, it added a graphic form to web pages, which multimedially combined text, graphics, video, and sound. This was done by students who participated in the NCSA programme (at the University of Illinois). Marc Andressen, who led the team, proposed to make the web a tool – based not only on text but also on graphics – that would be accessible for all people (Goban-Klas, 2005, pp. 149–151).

In 1994, Yahoo! was created as the first internet portal, with the aim of cataloguing all information and making it available to anyone using the internet. Its creators were Stanford University PhD students David Filo and Jerry Yang. A year later came the RealAudio technology, which allowed audio transmission to be sent over the internet. In October that year, Sun Microsystems launched the Java programming language, which is still one of the most popular tools used by internet programmers today. In the same year, the first internet search engine (AltaVista) was created. This content-search tool was the first multilingual search engine that catered for languages based on non-Latin alphabets, such as Japanese and Chinese. It had a Babelfish mechanism that offered tools for automatic page translation and searching for individual phrases and multimedia; this search engine was shut down by Yahoo on 8 July 2013 (Leszczyńska, 2019, p. 19).

Two Stanford University PhD students, Sergey Brin and Larry Page, created a search engine that indexed pages by quality. In this way, the Google search engine was created in 1998. The idea behind Google was simple: when indexing sites, the number of links from different sites that lead to individual pages is checked. At the same time, the importance of these links is analysed. This method also measures the social recognition of the selected sites, which is done by the number of links – the equivalent of citations in science. The algorithm of this search engine is constantly being developed and updated, and attention is paid to the quality of links from themed websites, web forums, blogs, and also government domains. This search engine, created by two students, has dominated the market; to meet the demands of this domination, Google uses a huge IT infrastructure which links hundreds of thousands of computers. The ambition of its creators was to make all information available on the web, so the Google News service was created, which

collects information from website newspapers (Rowlands, Nicholas, Williams et al., 2008, pp. 290–310).

## Discussion of the term

Since the early 1990s, there has been a steady upward trend in the internetisation of the population. In 2021, the world's population reached 7.83 billion, of which 4.66 billion people use the internet. This was an increase of 316 million, or 7.3%, from the previous year. Internet users accounted for 59.5% of the global population. The average daily time of internet use per user was 6 hours and 54 minutes. The number of mobile internet users (mobile and Wi-Fi) amounted to 4.32 billion (Digital, 2022). Even though the percentage of internet users increased from 0.4% in 1995 to 59.5% in 2021, this growth was not evenly distributed around the world and the rate is particularly low in sub-Saharan African states.

Subsequent generations of the internet are worth mentioning. Web 1.0 is a one-way form of communication called the web of cognition; Web 2.0 is the social web; Web 3.0 is intended to be the semantic web, while Web 4.0 is the mobile version of Web 2.0 (the mobile Web). Web 5.0 will be a version based on neurotechnology, which will allow selected biometric indicators to be interpreted and users' emotions to be identified, e.g., web applications will be able to change the facial expressions of avatars (images representing participants in a virtual world, e.g., a participant in an online forum) in real time (emotional web: open, linked, and intelligent Web) (Demczuk, 2020, p. 23–25).

The first wave of popularity of the internet was linked to the computer revolution and the spread of computers (in the period between 1995 and 2006). It covered wealthy Western states whose citizens could afford to buy a personal computer. The second wave (from 2007 onwards) was linked to the mobile revolution and the popularity of smartphones, smart-watches, and tablets and was initiated by Steve Jobs, who invented the iPhone at the time. The rapid growth of the popularity of the internet occurred thanks to the invention of the smartphone, which meant the benefits of internetisation could also be reaped by residents of poorer countries (Leszczyńska, 2019, p. 107).

According to the Digital 2022 report on the internet in Poland, the number of internet users relative to the total population is still increasing. In 2021, internet users accounted for 84.5% of all Poles, and by the beginning of 2022 it was already at 87% of the population (the whole population – regardless of age – is taken into account here). The group of social media users also increased significantly. In 2022, social media (social networks) was used by 27 million Poles. Social media covers all activities, practices, and behaviours among communities of people who connect online to share information and opinions. This is made possible through apps and various venues for sharing information in the form of words, video, and sound. The term refers to social media based on easily accessible and easy-to-use information and communication technologies (ICTs) (Digital 2022).

When analysing statistics, it is worth mentioning that the average Polish internet user is aged 16–64 and spends an average of 6 hours and 39 minutes per day online. Over 93% of internet users access the mobile internet on a smartphone. They use the internet on their phones for a shorter period of 2 hours and 58 minutes per day (whereas on laptops, tablets and desktops – 3 hours and 42 minutes). An interesting correlation is noticed here: today, large monitors are used primarily for professional rather than private activity (Digital, 2022).

There are several determinants for this dynamic popularisation of the internet. The main reason is that it has become the main channel of communication between people. Unlike the old media, the internet user has access to an endless supply of information at any time.

The internet has developed to such an extent that nowadays almost anyone can use it. We can observe the rapid growth of the number of users and of research and publications distributed on it by representatives of almost all scientific disciplines. It is already present in all areas of life, and we use its services in education and work. It took on a special dimension in these areas during the SARS-Cov-2 pandemic, when many people had to study and work remotely. The world of education, business, and entertainment can no longer function without the internet.

The internet is a means of communication which, for the first time in human history, allows many people to communicate at a time they choose and on a global scale. According to Manuel Castells, in the past the spread of the printing press in Europe brought people into the

'Gutenberg Galaxy', and today we are entering a new world of communication – the Internet Galaxy (Castells, 2001, p. 3). The contemporary development of civilisation in the age of globalisation is conditioned by the transformations taking place with the help of modern information technologies. The internet is a medium that has a significant impact on many areas of human activity. The availability of information and the freedom to communicate with others is much greater than ever.

In the network society, it is the media that are mostly connected to one another; if not, they still refer to one another in programs and services. It is thanks to the internet that video conferencing and instant access to information and data are possible. It is one of the fastest means of mass communication, with unparalleled efficiency. The internet provides continuous connectivity regardless of the time or place one is in. Internet services are constantly being improved and its resources expanded (Leszczyńska, 2019, p. 25).

Nowadays, a computer is no longer merely a tool for work – it is also a device for entertainment. The 2018 report of the Institute Infuture *Giga Entertainment. The Future of Entertainment in the Era of Gigabit Internet, AI, IoT and MEC* in 2018, which was commissioned by the UPC company, discussed the superfast internet, which would bring about great change in the development of digital entertainment. Respondents estimated that it would bring unlimited high-definition video anytime, anywhere. Internet connections would be used not only for television or computer games but also for areas related to education, travel, interpersonal relationships, and communication with others. Thanks to the development of the internet, entertainment elements have now entered various spheres of life, such as health, medicine, education, tourism, and culture. Even at the beginning of the 21<sup>st</sup> century, it was hard to imagine that it would be possible to watch TV programmes on a mobile phone, but today this is already standard. The development of virtual reality and artificial intelligence means that internet users have an increasingly broad spectrum of experiences, and thus inclusive experiences, regardless of their age or social background; the impact of technological, social, and economic factors on the future of entertainment is indeed huge (Infuture Institute, 2018).

One form of entertainment is social networks, which include Facebook, YouTube, Instagram, and Twitter. Facebook makes it possible to

connect and keep in touch with friends, chat with them, add photos, and also fosters modern online advertising. The internet user has become a sender and receiver of information, views and ideas, both legal and harmful. Illegal and harmful information includes online content that causes suffering, harm, and infringement to legally protected goods. As continuous technological progress leads to the need to protect new areas of human activity, the definition of what is harmful is changing and includes intimidation, harassment, incitement to hatred, and promotion of acts of violence (Demczuk, 2020, p. 27). YouTube is one of the most popular social networks in the world; it allows users to upload, play, rate, and comment on videos for free. Many people have managed to make a name for themselves through this portal. Once a video is posted on YouTube, it reaches a wide audience, which allows its author to gain the popularity and sympathy of internet users. Instagram is a photo-hosting social network that is linked to an app of the same name, which allows users to edit photos and videos. Twitter is a microblogging service: a registered user can send and read tweets which are short text messages of up to 280 characters (Digital, 2022).

In the Web 2.0 era, new trends emerged through social media. These include a deluge of information and disinformation, the deliberate creation of manipulated fake news, deep fakes, and trash streams (i.e., demoralising content presented by trash streamers in the form of webcasts that go against social norms because they promote psychological, physical, and sexual violence). With the use of social media, it has become possible to create a media and political culture called post-truth, which is emotionally charged and is often characterised by low-quality content. Associated with this are post-experts (i.e., people who are self-avowed experts), who are ready to explain even the most complicated problem in two sentences. Another negative phenomenon is the growing presence of hate speech, which stigmatises people because of their innate or acquired characteristics, encourages hatred, and perpetuates hate speech in public life (Demczuk, 2020, pp. 26–27).

In addition, the issue of social media conceived as a kind of public good, even when owned by private entities, is definitely worth paying attention to. In this way, the public and private spheres overlap, although they are formally still separate entities. Being in a public space, we enjoy freedom of expression, and social media is undoubtedly a public sphere.

However, the private owners of the media are often influential people with links to business and political parties and who conduct their own political agenda. For this reason, some opinions and views are banned on social media, which is justified by referring to content, hate speech, and discrimination. These can be accusations against individuals, groups, or even institutions. Private owners do not actually have to justify their content-control decisions as they can base them on their own discretion and the belief that they are protecting their users and even the foundations of democracy. Ideologically, they can claim to defend fundamental values such as freedom and equality (Kaczorowski, 2021).

The internet can also be a tool of social engineering. An example is the British political consulting firm Cambridge Analytica, which created psychological profiles of users' voting preferences in order to create relevant messages that could affect their individual decisions. Donald Trump's victory in the US presidential election and the UK citizens' decision to leave the European Union are considered to have been influenced by social engineering.

After the attacks on Capitol Hill in 2021, a lot of controversy was caused by Twitter's decision to block US President Donald Trump's account. Trump's account had 88 million followers and was his primary form of communication. This was the first time in history that a social media platform had blocked a head of state. Trump had repeatedly used Twitter and other platforms to claim that his defeat in the presidential election was due to widespread voter fraud. He had shared other conspiracy theories and called on supporters to come to Washington to protest the outcome of the election, which happened on 6 January 2021 when thousands of his supporters stormed the Capitol and numerous acts of vandalism took place. The decision to block Trump's account was also taken by Instagram, YouTube, and Facebook, which sparked discussions about the limited powers of online companies. The accounts of the then-incumbent US president have been permanently deleted. While his incitement to violence required a response, obviously such a radical decision is controversial. Critics emphasised the fact that his accounts were removed without referring to precise criteria, which in their view went against freedom of expression (Gounari, 2021, pp. 66–99).

The internet is also playing an increasing role in the polarisation of Western societies. This is influenced by troll farms and fake social media

accounts (bots) which fuel divisions in Western societies – a strategy employed by the People’s Republic of China and the Russian Federation, both of which support disinformation campaigns. The term ‘troll’ describes an individual who is paid to add content and support specific narratives online. Trolls, who can work in the offices of troll farms and/or remotely, usually post on behalf of specialised political and internet marketing entities. They are an important player in the market for social media manipulation services, which allow them to influence the direction of discussions taking place online and obtain much higher page views through certain content. An example is a Russian farm in St. Petersburg that is known as the ‘Trolls from Olgino’ or ‘the web brigade’ and creates posts and comments to spread Russian propaganda via social networks, online publications, or other resources on the web. The largest known scale of this type of phenomena is the activities of online commentators in China, who support the narratives of the Chinese government and the Chinese Communist Party with their posts. Bots are applications that automate activities specified by their creators. Originally, they mainly performed simple, repetitive tasks of a technical and ordering nature. Automated accounts can be newly created accounts, seized accounts, or purchased accounts. Bots and their services are now commercially traded and bots of varying degrees of sophistication and with different operating histories can be purchased. They are commonly used by troll farms, where many paid trolls use them to increase productivity. In this way, the same bots can be used in different countries (Grycuk, 2020, pp. 3–5).

In the context of social media, it is also worth mentioning the right to privacy. Facebook is the best example of this issue as its users provide their personal data when registering in order to have a profile. In return, being a user of this service offers many opportunities, e.g., keeping in touch with other people, joining certain groups, posting photos, exchanging opinions, recommending websites to friends, etc. It is true that privacy settings make it possible for users to make their profiles publicly accessible or visible only to certain persons, but it is important to remember that users’ personal information is passed on to other entities, such as Facebook companies and external partners. There are many risks to human privacy in the virtual world, especially the possibility of losing personal data. The examples of the many different data ‘leaks’ are too numerous to count. It is worth paying attention not only

to social networks but also to other e-services. The implementation of the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) was a step in the right direction, but it did not radically change the situation. Previously, the right was limited only to requesting a search engine operator to remove links from a list of search results, especially where a surname was involved. Today, this right has a broader scope of application and applies not only to search engine operators but also to administrators (Jabłoński and Węgrzyn, 2020, pp. 80–81).

Cybercrime is an increasingly common phenomenon on the web. This term covers all illegal activities undertaken with the help and by means of the internet. Such activities can have different reaches and affect either individual systems and computers or the wider infrastructure; even government websites and servers are sometimes blocked. The most common crimes of this type include phishing, the aim of which is to obtain important data, such as login information; hacking, which involves illegally breaking into someone's computer; and malware, which is a malicious type of software for stealing data, destroying files, or even blocking access to a device. Another example of digital crime related to social media is cyberstalking, which is cyberbullying carried out by a stalker by sending unwanted messages to another person via various instant messaging platforms or by email. Cybercrime also includes other activities carried out via the internet, such as fake sellers on auction portals and illegally copying films or music and distributing them. Crimes involving cryptocurrencies are also on the rise.

The internet is a major component of the technological infrastructure of the state, supranational structures, and international structures. The technology is constantly evolving and can be used in business (e-commerce), government (e-government), administration (e-administration), education (e-learning), health care (e-health), and work (teleworking). Social media leads to the dynamic development of digital communities, thus constantly creating new political, social, and economic situations that society and policy makers must respond to. Technology has become the primary means of communication between governments and citizens. The changing conditions of the functioning of the state enforce adaptive processes that are a challenge for political practice and the process of cognition (Demczuk, 2020, p. 30).

Since the early 1990s, we have been observing the dynamic development of the internet, which has become the main channel of communication between people. It plays a vital role in all areas of life: work, education, and entertainment. It is a major component of the technological infrastructure of both states and international structures. Social networking sites are becoming increasingly important, and the number of their users is growing steadily. Negative aspects of the internet include the deliberate creation of manipulated fake news, its use as a tool of social engineering that can influence elections, and the rising phenomenon of cybercrime.

## Systematic reflection with conclusions and recommendations

The internet contributes to the emergence and development of citizens' initiatives, both political and those concerning other spheres of social life. Frequently, initiatives which begin online are later transferred beyond the 'virtual' sphere, even though they are coordinated through it. The internet allows a growing number of people to use this previously unknown media, which leads to the formation of new forms of social activity and the spread of their use. It also forms the basis of a new society that exists in a virtual space on its own terms, with its own institutions, norms, culture, cultural elites, and power groups. The internet society binds people together on many levels; real social processes take place in it; battles for goods are fought, and coalitions are formed. The position of the user in the internet society is often as important as his position in the real world (Dorenda-Zaborowicz, 2014, p. 30).

The internet offers great opportunities for development, but the web is also a source of various challenges and risks related to privacy, addiction, and security. By providing unlimited entertainment, it makes it difficult for users to perform their daily duties. Those who are able to use the web in an instrumental way experience its positive effects, while those for whom the web is primarily a source of entertainment often simply waste time. However, this does not change the fact that the presence of the internet in the life of modern man is constant and affects his cognitive functions: it shapes new values, emotions, and needs. It has a considerable impact

on social development and on relationships with other people, in the same way as television once did (Leszczyńska, 2019, pp. 29–30).

In the long term, internet use fosters social relationships developed outside the virtual space, and the positive impact it has on social relationships is associated with a significant increase in the number of users. As access to the internet becomes more widespread, so too does the amount of the users' friends and family members who join the web. The internet is increasingly becoming a medium that serves to maintain existing strong ties rather than just establishing new but weak relationships. Research confirms this observation: internet users keep in touch with family and friends more often if they can use email and instant messaging to do so (Leszczyńska, 2019, p. 115). The development and spread of the internet is a fundamental factor that fosters both social change and the emergence of a network society. One can argue about the scope of this change, but technological innovations in the field of information technology have already fundamentally influenced almost every aspect of society and culture.

The internet plays a key role in the globalisation process. In the contemporary world, the circulation of information, and consequently all the techniques, institutions, and organisations that shape it in one way or another, is growing in importance. The internet is a source of both reliable information and information that does not form any structured narrative. In this way, the importance of traditional mass media is waning. Humanity has entered a new, second stage in the development of a globally informed and networked society. For several years, the Economist Intelligence Unit has been studying the Inclusive Internet Index. Its 2019 edition was created based on the criteria of accessibility, affordability, relevance, and readiness. States with low per capita income reported a lack of progress in terms of access to the internet and improved network coverage (Demczuk, 2020, p. 62).

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